PART IV · CHORDS · TIPS

When a chord sounds wrong

A chord that sounds wrong usually has one small slip. Name the slip, fix that one note, and the chord comes right.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
A chord sounds sour	**the kind**: keys between, 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	p. 90
Your hand jumps all over	**an inversion**: keep the shared note still	p. 96
A big chord sounds muddy	**leave notes out**: drop the 5th first	p. 105
A seventh chord sounds wrong	**the 7th**: G7 adds F, ten semitones above G	p. 99
A sus chord sounds unfinished	**the 4th**: it wants to fall one key to the 3rd	p. 102
The bass note sounds odd	**the slash**: the letter after it is the lowest note	p. 108

Four ways to learn chords fast

1. **Build, then play**
   Say the snowman (C E G) before your fingers go down.

2. **Hands alone first**
   Left hand chords alone, then the tune alone, then together.

3. **One trip a week**
   Learn one progression, then play it in three keys.

4. **Listen for the kind**
   Play major and minor side by side: bright, then dark.

EXAMPLE

Fix a sour chord



1. **It sounds dark**, but the music wants a bright C chord.
2. **Count the keys between:** 2, then 3. That is minor.
3. **Move one note:** E♭ up to E makes 3 + 2. Bright again.

One note was off: **fix the middle of the snowman**.

THINK OF IT Like a mechanic: one odd sound points to one part. Fix that part and the engine runs smoothly.